



JOHNY THOMAS

DELHI | Out of the League

It was hardly a surprise when the CPI(M) Politburo unceremoniously removed Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan from the party's highest body. Adding injury to that insult, the Politburo gave a clean chit to Pinarayi Vijayan, the powerful state secretary of the party's Kerala's unit. Vijayan has the dubious honour of being the first ever Politburo member to be chargesheeted by the CBI in a corruption scandal. He is accused of irregularities in a power deal struck while he was the state electricity minister in the mid-1990s. Even as party leaders looked the other way, Achuthanandan kept reiterating his determination to the Lavalin power deal, mostly to further his cause in factional feuds against Vijayan. With his dismissal, the Politburo and Central Committee members of the party seem most out of sync with public opinion over the issue. Achuthanandan is not likely to take his ouster quietly. The corruption case will come up in court soon and the chief minister is expected to up the ante and embarrass his tormentors. After being routed in the national polls, the CPI(M)-led Left Front's hopes of retaining power in the state are virtually extinct. V.R. Krishna Iyer, a former Supreme Court judge and fellow traveller of the Left, accused Prakash Karat and comrades of being the pall-bearers of the Communist party. No tears will be shed at this funeral.

ACHUTHANANDAN,
KARAT AND
VIJAYAN (L-R)

by Shafi Rahman

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years, the amount of time that Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan had been a member of the CPI(M) Politburo.